

Regular Pioneer Hour Review and Shepherding Guide

Evidence-backed working aid. Current official direction and original documents remain authoritative.

Audience: Elders' working topic · **Reviewed:** 2026-09-05

Confidentiality: The controlling Shepherd material is confidential. Keep this derived working topic within the authorised elders' project and do not circulate it as a public policy statement.

Authority boundary: This is a paraphrased working aid based on the September 2025 Shepherd edition and the public Organized book. Check the current Shepherd Addendum, JW Hub instructions and Branch direction before acting.

600

annual
requirement

50

monthly review
average

560

year-end
continuation
benchmark

Prompt

Service Committee
review below 560

Bottom line

Do not begin by asking a pioneer to step down. First verify the record, understand the person's circumstances and offer help. A total below 560 hours at service-year end requires a prompt, balanced Congregation Service Committee determination; it is not automatic deletion. If discontinuation is best, present it as a potentially temporary, stress-relieving adjustment—not as discipline or a judgment of spiritual worth.

Thresholds and what they mean

Measure	Figure	Direction	Reference
Annual requirement	600 hours	An applicant should have organised personal affairs so the annual requirement can realistically be reached.	SFG 14:1(3)
Review indicator	Consistently below an average of 50 hours per month	After factoring in hour credit, the service overseer and group overseer meet with the pioneer to offer assistance and assess whether the annual requirement is realistic.	SFG 14:5
Year-end continuation benchmark	At least 560 hours	Hours in field service plus applicable hour credit; the pioneer may continue.	SFG 14:6

Measure	Figure	Direction	Reference
Year-end decision point	Below 560 hours	The Service Committee promptly decides whether the pioneer should continue, using balanced judgment. This is not an automatic deletion rule.	SFG 14:6-7

Important: 600 hours is the annual requirement; 560 hours is the separate year-end benchmark stated in Shepherd for continuation. Do not replace either figure with a locally invented rule.

Decision flow

1. Verify the record

Owner: Secretary / Service Overseer · **Reference:** SFG 14:5-8

- ☐ Confirm the service year and months appointed
- ☐ Reconcile reported field-service hours
- ☐ Confirm properly recorded hour credit
- ☐ Check for missing or late reports
- ☐ Identify approved theocratic-project work that may require special consideration

2. Meet to understand and assist

Owner: Service Overseer / Group Overseer · **Reference:** SFG 14:5

- ☐ The service overseer and appropriate group overseer meet with the pioneer
- ☐ Commend specific faithful service
- ☐ Ask about health, family, employment, schedule and other circumstances
- ☐ Offer practical help before discussing discontinuation
- ☐ Assess whether the new service year's requirement is realistically sustainable

3. Check special provisions

Owner: Congregation Service Committee / Body of elders · **Reference:** SFG 14:3, 8-10

- ☐ Consider approved-project special consideration
- ☐ Consider the rare infirm-pioneer provision only if all criteria may apply
- ☐ Consult the circuit overseer where the infirm provision requires it
- ☐ Check the current Addendum and JW Hub direction

4. Make a balanced determination

Owner: Congregation Service Committee · **Reference:** SFG 14:6-7

- ☐ Consider the length of full-time service
- ☐ Consider age and whether circumstances are temporary or continuing
- ☐ Consider the pioneer's best interests
- ☐ Uphold the standard for regular pioneer service
- ☐ Do not leave a below-560 case unresolved or place the burden on the pioneer to volunteer a resignation

5. Communicate and record the outcome

Owner: Congregation Service Committee · **Reference:** SFG 14:3, 8-10

- ☐ Update the body of elders before an announcement
- ☐ If discontinuing, two Service Committee members inform the individual first
- ☐ Use the current JW Hub process
- ☐ Use only the prescribed announcement
- ☐ Record special or infirm consideration on S-21 when applicable

Provisions and circumstances to distinguish

Situation	Criteria	Possible outcome	Reference
Approved-project special consideration	The pioneer missed the annual requirement because extensive work on approved theocratic projects exceeded the hour credit available.	The pioneer may continue, should be warmly commended and has the special consideration noted on S-21.	SFG 14:8
Infirm regular pioneer	Rare provision: exemplary, over 50 years old, at least 15 cumulative years pioneering and a heartfelt desire to continue; the circuit overseer must be consulted.	If the body approves, the pioneer may serve without an hour requirement; two Service Committee members explain the provision and it is noted on S-21.	SFG 14:9
Ordinary changed circumstances	Health, employment, family responsibilities or another adverse circumstance makes the annual requirement unrealistic but does not meet a special provision.	Temporary discontinuation may be in the person's best interests and relieve pressure until circumstances change.	SFG 14:6-7

How to conduct the conversation

Principles

- Use the meeting to listen and assist, not to announce a predetermined outcome.
- Separate the privilege of regular pioneering from the person's spirituality and value to Jehovah or the congregation.
- Use verified figures without accusatory expressions such as 'you failed to make your time.'
- Do not pressure the pioneer to chase an unsafe or unrealistic deficit.
- If discontinuation is considered, use the official idea of discontinuing for a time rather than the status-oriented expression 'step down.'

Questions that invite an honest assessment

- How have you been, and what circumstances affected your ministry during the service year?
- Is any report or approved hour credit missing from the record?
- What practical assistance could the elders or congregation provide?
- Looking at your present circumstances, is reaching the annual requirement during the new service year realistic?
- Would a workable adjustment make continuation sustainable, or would discontinuing for a time relieve pressure until circumstances change?

Suggested opening

We appreciate your service and want this to be an encouraging conversation, not a disciplinary one. Your value to Jehovah and the congregation is not measured by a title or a number of hours. We would first like to understand what affected your service, confirm that the record is accurate and see what practical help we can offer. Then we can consider together whether continuing regular pioneer service is realistic in your present circumstances.

Avoid

- Beginning with a predetermined request that the person discontinue.
- Saying, “You failed to make your time,” or implying that the congregation was let down.
- Equating hours or a pioneer appointment with Jehovah’s approval of the person.
- Pressuring the pioneer to pursue an unsafe or unrealistic catch-up schedule.
- Leaving a year-end case below 560 hours unresolved.

If discontinuation is determined

1. Obtain and consider the appropriate group overseer’s comments.
2. Check whether special consideration or the infirm-pioneer provision applies.
3. The Congregation Service Committee makes the determination using balanced judgment.
4. Update the body of elders before any announcement.
5. Two Service Committee members inform the pioneer personally before the announcement.
6. Use the current JW Hub procedure and only the prescribed announcement.
7. Continue warm shepherding; a temporary discontinuation is not discipline and does not diminish the person’s faithful service.

Ashburton transition application

- **Who handles the completed service year:** Until 1 November 2026, the pioneer remains under the current congregation, so that congregation’s Service Committee should resolve the completed service-year review.
- **What the transfer letter must resolve:** The letter of introduction should plainly state whether the existing body recommends that the pioneer continue.
- **What the new congregation does:** If the recommendation is favourable, the new Ashburton Tagalog Congregation Service Committee confirms that the pioneer wishes to continue and, absent an exceptional reason, arranges the announcement at the next midweek meeting.
- **Reference:** SFG 14:4; approval letter p. 2

Practical control: Resolve or clearly document each regular pioneer’s recommendation before the 1 November transfer. The new congregation should not inherit an ambiguous pioneer status.

Sources

- Shepherd the Flock of God — September 2025 — Chapter 14, paragraphs 1, 3-10; confidential controlling local source.
- Organized to Do Jehovah’s Will — Chapter 10, paragraphs 11-13; public official source.
- The Christian Congregation—A Source of Strengthening Aid — The experience concerning guilt after discontinuing pioneering; public pastoral support.
- Were You Once a Regular Pioneer? — Paragraph 4; public pastoral support.

Generated from `data/00-project.json`. This portal does not replace S-50, S-51, or current direction from the circuit overseer or branch office.